PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

Women and the War — A House Divided

How Do We Measure What Women Changed?

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about Women and the War — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Significance isn't about fame. A historian asks: how deeply did it change things, and how long did that change last?

THE SOURCES

THE IMAGE — Clara Barton



Clara Barton — photographic portrait, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE · THE HOME-FRONT WORKFORCE — Women at the arsenal

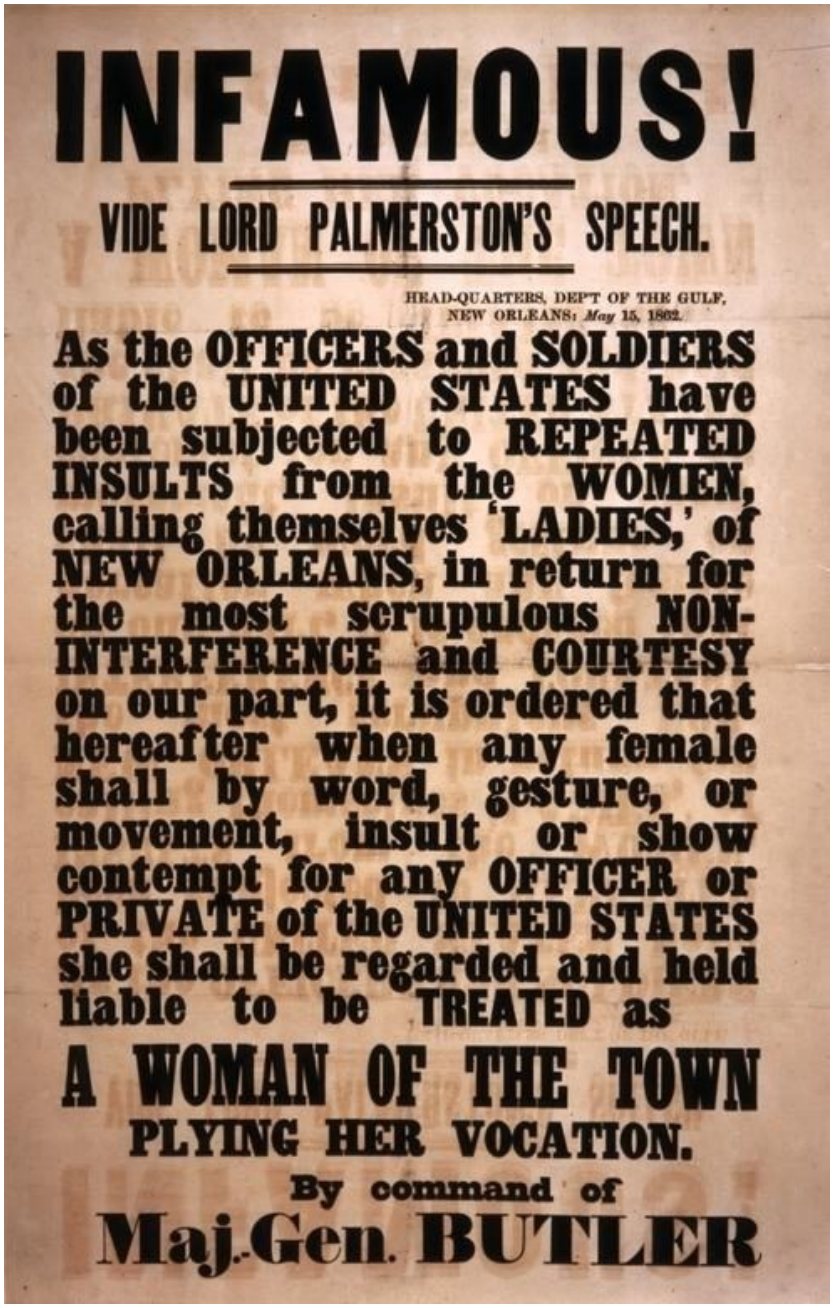


FILLING CARTRIDGES AT THE UNITED STATES ARSENAL, AT WATERTOWN, MASSACHUSETTS.—[See next Page.]

Thousands of women took paid — and dangerous — factory work filling cartridges and shells, new wage labor the war opened to them

"Filling Cartridges at the United States Arsenal, Watertown, Massachusetts" — wood engraving, Harper's Weekly, 1861, public domain.

SOURCE · WOMEN AND THE ENEMY — Butler's "Woman Order," New Orleans, 1862



When women of occupied New Orleans insulted Union soldiers, Butler ordered that any who did so be treated "as a woman of the town." Even hostile orders admitted women were full participants in the war

"Infamous!" — General Orders No. 28, the "Woman Order," issued by Maj. Gen. B. F. Butler, New Orleans, 1862 — broadside, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE · ROLES WOMEN FILLED, 1861–1865 — A partial list

Battlefield nurses · managers of farms, shops, and plantations · fundraisers and supply organizers (U.S. Sanitary Commission) · spies and scouts for both armies · a few hundred disguised soldiers · enslaved women who fled to Union lines, and leaders like Harriet Tubman who guided them to freedom.
— compiled from standard histories of the period. Public domain

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YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · SORT THE ROLES

From the source, choose four different roles women played and write one sentence on how each helped the war effort or the people in it.

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · WHAT COUNTS AS SIGNIFICANT?

A historian judging significance would say women's war work mattered most because it —

- ☐ A. made women instantly equal to men
- ☐ B. was written up in every battle report
- ☐ C. proved what women could do, feeding the postwar women's rights movement
- ☐ D. had no effect once the war ended

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · DIFFERENT BURDENS

Enslaved women carried burdens free women did not — and many used the war to escape toward freedom. Why is it important that a history of 'women and the war' include enslaved women like Harriet Tubman, not just nurses like Barton?

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · WHY IT MATTERS

The war did not give women the vote. So was women's war work historically significant or not? Take a position and defend it in two or three sentences, using the idea of lasting change.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — Women and the War — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "1) Nurses... 2) Farm/plantation managers... 3) Spies... 4) ..."

QUESTION 2: **Correct — C. proved what women could do, feeding the postwar women's rights movement**

Right. Significance is about lasting change. By proving women could run institutions and do skilled work, the war fed directly into the postwar women's rights movement — a change that outlived the war itself.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Including enslaved women matters because..."

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "I would judge women's war work as ___ significant because..."